(SHGs). Purnima Sardar, a housewife from Bermajur in her late twenties, says that she quit the local SHG due to the irregularities. "Why will I pay Rs 50 for every kid or chick when I am supposed to get them for free?" she asks.

Nor was government relief material in the wake of cyclones like Amphan, Aila and Fani exempt, all of it was allegedly taxed by local politicans. For a piece of tarpaulin or a few steel utensils, local TMC men would levy a charge of Rs 20-30, says Purnima. Pointing to her rickety, unfinished house, Anjana Das from Jeliakhali village says that she received the first two instalments of money under the PMAY scheme, but none thereafter. "When we went to ask for the subsequent payments, TMC men told us they are keeping the money as service charge," she says.

Villagers point out other instances of alleged corruption. A worn-out stone plaque proclaims the building of a jetty on the Kalagachhia river in Sandeshkhali-II using Rs 4 lakh from the MLA Local Area Development Scheme. However, all that exists is a skeletal structure of around 40 steps leading to the muddy river bank where no boat has ever docked. "I work as a mason and I can tell you that this structure couldn't have cost more than Rs 40,000. The rest of the Rs 4 lakh has gone to the pockets of local Trinamool Congress netas," alleges young Bidyut Sardar, a local resident. According to the plaque, funds for the jetty were allocated in 2015-16, when CPI(M)'s Nirapada Sardar represented Sandeshkhali in the West Bengal assembly. The stairs were constructed later, says Bidyut. TMC's Sukumar Mahata, who has been the local MLA since 2016, denies any knowledge about the jetty. "If the money was sanctioned in 2015-16, ask Nirapada Sardar about it. He was the MLA then," he says.

Then there are allegations of electoral malpractices. Bidyut says he last voted 10 years ago. Many in Sandeshkhali claimed that since 2013, when Shahjahan was first elected to the local panchayat, not just Opposition party members/ supporters, even many TMC workers were not allowed to vote. Some allege methodical rigging. According to data collected from the website of the State Election Commission, only the TMC could field candidates in each of the 4,535 gram panchayat seats in North 24 Parganas, under which both blocks of Sandeshkhali fall, during the rural polls of 2023. All eight gram panchayats under Sandeshkhali II were won uncontested by the TMC. In Sandeshkhali I, 85 per cent of all seats were won by the TMC unopposed.



"The arrest of one Shahjahan is nothing; TMC has reared hundreds of Shahjahans. People have revolted, TMC will be reduced to single digits in the Lok Sabha polls"

SAMIK BHATTACHARYA
BJP spokesperson and Rajya Sabha MP



"Sandeshkhali will never impact electoral results. Whatever the fault was, it is being rectified. The accused have been arrested"

PARTHA BHOWMICK
TMC leader and West Bengal minister

Damage Control

The TMC's efforts to control the damage—after blaming the Opposition of fomenting trouble and blocking their access to the area—saw the deployment of senior ministers Partha Bhowmick and Sujit Bose to placate irate villagers and setting around 100 grievance redressal camps. While Sandeshkhali I received only 28 land-related complaints, Sandeshkhali II logged over 500 complaints where, till March 1, 239 pieces of land have been returned to their owners. "We had received 2,000 to 2,500 complaints of all sorts. All are being looked into," says Arun Kumar Samanta, the block development officer of Sandeshkhali II.

According to the BJP and the CPI(M), Sandeshkhali is a microcosm of TMC rule in Bengal. "The arrest of one Shahjahan means nothing, as the TMC has reared hundreds of Shahjahans. People have started revolting against this politics of terror," says Samik Bhattacharya, Rajya Sabha MP and the BJP's chief spokesperson for West Bengal. He says the TMC will be reduced to single digits this Lok Sabha election. CPI(M) state secretary Mohammed Salim also speaks in the same vein. "Sandeshkhali has removed the lid. TMC has made such 'liberalised' zones across Bengal.... The people have started speaking up; the fire has ignited and this will grow," he says.

The TMC itself has no alternative but to put up a brave face. "Sandeshkhali will never impact electoral results.... Whatever the fault was, it is being rectified. The accused have been arrested," says industries minister and TMC leader Partha Bhowmick.

Psephologist Biswanath Chakraborty says the Muslim-dominated Basirhat Lok Sabha constituency—under which Sandeshkhali falls—will continue to be a TMC bastion. "However, the incident is likely to have an impact on the other constituencies. It has given the BJP an impetus and might help it win seats dominated by the general Hindu or Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes," he added. It certainly won't be an easy summer for the TMC. ■